

Pre-Planning Guide

Planning ahead gives you time to make thoughtful choices, locks in today's pricing, and lifts a tremendous burden from the people you love.

WHY PRE-PLAN · DECISIONS TO MAKE · 3-STEP PROCESS · PRINTABLE

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SECTION 1

Why Pre-Plan?

A gift of clarity and peace of mind for your family

When a death happens unexpectedly, families face **dozens of decisions** in a matter of days — often while grieving, exhausted, and under financial pressure. Pre-planning lets you make those choices **on your own terms**, with time to think, compare, and discuss.

Pre-planning is not just about your own preferences. It's about the people you'll leave behind. Families who have a pre-plan consistently say it was **the most meaningful gift** their loved one gave them — because it removed the burden of guessing.

A pre-plan can be as simple or detailed as you'd like. You can plan the big decisions (cremation or burial, where to be placed) and leave the smaller ones to your family, or you can specify every detail down to the flowers and music.

WHAT FAMILIES TELL US

- "We didn't have to make any hard decisions during the worst week of our lives."
- "Mom planned everything — it was her last act of taking care of us."
- "We had no idea what Dad wanted. We wish he had told us."

SECTION 2

Decisions to Make

The choices families face — and the ones you can make in advance

There are **more decisions than most people realize**. Pre-planning lets you work through them at your own pace, rather than all at once under pressure.



Cremation or Burial?

The most fundamental choice. Each opens different options for services, caskets, and final resting place.



Where to Rest?

Cemetery section, columbarium niche, urn garden, scattering garden, or another location entirely.



Type of Service?

Traditional funeral with viewing, memorial service, graveside service, celebration of life, or private family gathering.



Casket or Urn?

Over 200 caskets and 248 urns to choose from — or let your family decide from your shortlist.



Marker or Monument?

Flush granite marker, bronze marker, or upright monument (where permitted). Color, size, inscription.



Photo Portrait?

Ceramic steel photo on the marker? Diamond etching? Which photo to use?



Obituary & Records

How many death certificates? Who to notify? What should the obituary say?



Personal Touches

Flowers, music, readings, pallbearers, charitable donations in lieu of flowers.

The 3-Step Process

Pre-planning is simpler than you think

I

Meet with a Counselor

A free, no-pressure conversation at the cemetery, in your home, or by phone. We'll walk through your options and answer every question.

2

Make Your Selections

Choose your services, resting place, casket or urn, and marker. Take your time — there's no deadline and no rush.

3

Put It in Writing

We document everything and provide your family with a copy. When the time comes, we handle everything exactly as you planned.

No Obligation, No Pressure

A pre-planning consultation is **completely free**. You're welcome to meet once, take months to decide, and come back when you're ready. Many families start with a simple conversation and return later to finalize details.

You can also make changes to your pre-plan at any time. Life changes, and your plan can change with it.

SECTION 4

Cremation & Burial Options

A brief overview of the two primary paths

Your pre-plan starts with one fundamental question: **cremation or burial?** Both are available at Washington Memorial Park, and both can include a full range of services.

Cremation Plans

Direct cremation — simplest and most affordable. No service, remains returned to family.

Cremation with memorial — cremation first, followed by a memorial service at a later date.

Cremation with viewing — a traditional viewing or funeral before cremation takes place.

Burial Plans

Traditional burial — viewing, funeral service, and interment at the cemetery.

Graveside service — a service held at the graveside, often simpler and more intimate.

Entombment — above-ground placement in a mausoleum (limited availability).

Each path includes choices about **services, merchandise, and cemetery property**. Your counselor will walk you through every option and build a customized quote so you can see the full picture before committing to anything.

SECTION 5

Financial Benefits

Pre-planning protects against rising costs



Lock In Today's Prices

Cemetery property, services, and merchandise prices increase over time. A pre-plan purchased today is honored at today's prices, regardless of when it is needed.



Flexible Payment Options

Pay in full or set up a payment plan that fits your budget. No interest on cemetery property payments.



Asset Protection

Pre-paid funeral and cemetery arrangements may be exempt from Medicaid spend-down requirements in Washington state. Consult your attorney or financial advisor for specifics.



No Financial Burden on Family

Your family won't face a large, unexpected expense during an already difficult time. Everything is taken care of.

SECTION 6

Common Questions

What families ask most about pre-planning

**Is pre-planning the same as pre-paying?**

No. You can pre-plan (make selections and document your wishes) without paying anything upfront. Pre-paying is optional and locks in pricing.

**Can I change my pre-plan later?**

Yes. Life circumstances change, and your plan can change with them. Contact your counselor to make adjustments at any time.

**What if I move out of the area?**

Cemetery property at Washington Memorial Park is yours regardless of where you live. Funeral service arrangements can be transferred or adjusted.

**Do I need to decide everything right now?**

Not at all. Many families start with the big decisions (cremation or burial, location) and fill in details over time. Any amount of planning helps.

**How do I get started?**

Call or email your counselor for a free, no-pressure conversation. We can meet at the cemetery, at your home, or by phone.



Serving Seattle families since 1868 · Washington Memorial Park

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